PS 101: The 2026 Midterm Elections

Course Schedule and Outline

Instructor: Professor Michael Alvarez

Note: This is a preliminary schedule and is subject to change!

Meeting Time: Tuesday/Thursday 10:30 am - 11:55 am

Office Hours (Baxter 103): By appointment (rma@caltech.edu).

Meeting Location: Baxter B125

1. Course Requirements and Expectations

Learning outcomes:

Grading: This class is offered grades-only. Class attendance and participation (40%); four in-class assessments, four (5% each); final research report and presentation (40%). There will periodically be extra credit for participation in certain events, those extra credit opportunities will be announced in class and on Canvas. Generally extra credit opportunities will be graded and will be worth 50% of an in-class reflection.

Research projects: Students will undertake a research project that they will complete during the quarter, focusing on building some solution for contemporary election analysis or election administration issues. Research projects are an integral part of this class, and will be the source of periodic class discussion.

Class materials: When we need to share materials we will use Caltech Google Drive (https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1VVBr_lE3UYIzTOb1EWQ5Wk9mUuQXZkSv?usp=sharing).

In-class reflections: These will be short assessments designed to evaluate retention of class discussions and readings and will be conducted in class.

Due dates: All presentations and other materials are due as specified on the times and dates listed below. A late assignment will lose a full letter grade if turned in within 24 hours of the deadline; two full letter grades if turned in between 24 and 48 hours late; it will not be graded if turned in more than 48 hours late.

Collaboration policy: The research projects can be done by each student individually, or in teams of two students. The research, presentations, and writing are to be original to the individual or team, thus no collaboration outside of each research team (without the express permission of the instructor). The final report, in-class presentation, and final briefings of class

research projects will be graded by project; if a student conducts the research project independently, he or she will receive the grade provided; if two students collaborate as a team on a research project the project will receive a midterm, final, and presentation grade and the two students will receive the project's grade.

Class meetings: We are planning on meeting in person this quarter, though we may periodically have our class meetings on Zoom (the instructor will send the Zoom meeting links in Canvas). Students should not distribute the Zoom links. We will have some classes with guests or classes with guests on Zoom, these will be announced during the quarter.

Class attendance: Class attendance is important, much of the work we will do will be in class or in the field. We will take class attendance. But your health and wellbeing is also important. Attendance and participation will constitute 40% of the grade for the course. Students who cannot attend or participate in a particular class because they are sick, believe they may be sick will NOT be penalized. If you feel sick, are sick, or have been in contact with someone who is sick, please do not come to class in person. Simply let the instructor know that you cannot come to class, and we will make sure that you get all course materials for any class sessions that you miss.

Sometimes the technology may not operate optimally for some or all of us. If the instructor is unable to connect via Zoom, or the particular Zoom session fails, we will try to reschedule or the instructor will try to provide a recorded version of the course lecture. If the Zoom session fails to work for students, please let the instructor know on Slack and we will try to work out a make-up session as well as try to do what we can to resolve technical issues.

Technology Use: When we are meeting in person please silence your personal technological devices and refrain from the use of your phones. When we are having a class lecture use of a laptop or tablet is possible for note taking. For class discussions and student presentations please refrain from the use of your devices unless you are presenting, so as to provide the best interactive experience for everyone. During the in-class reflections technology use will not be permitted. The instructor will announce in class when it's a good idea to refrain from the use of technology and to focus on discussions and presentations.

Civility in Class: This is a political science course, and at points in time we may address and discuss thought-provoking, controversial, and sometimes polarizing historical, social and political subjects. Also, in the past, students have chosen a wide variety of topics to research, including those relating to racism and discrimination, past and present. Open discussion is a key component of this class. However, it is not necessary to share or use racist or other offensive language in citing or sharing primary source material or in expressing thoughts and opinions. In particular, students should notify the instructor in advance of citations to or sharing of primary source material using offensive language, so that we can formulate parameters that allow our class to be inclusive and respectful of all participating students.

Academic Integrity:

***Caltech's Honor Code*:** "No member of the Caltech community shall take unfair advantage of any other member of the Caltech community."

***Understanding and Avoiding Plagiarism*:** Plagiarism is the appropriation of another person's ideas, processes, results, or words without giving appropriate credit, and it violates the honor code in a fundamental way. You can find more information at: http://writing.caltech.edu/resources/plagiarism.

***HSS Plagiarism Guidelines and Expectations*:** All students are expected to read and abide by these guidelines, https://hss.caltech.edu/academics/avoiding-plagiarismLinks to an external site..

***Generative AI*:** Students can use Generative AI for all aspects of research projects. However, use of Generative AI must be clearly disclosed, detailing what components of a project report or presentation Generative AI was used for. For the research projects, you must provide the prompts used for all aspects of the project, session summaries, and all code or other materials that are AI-generated. These materials must be provided upon completion of the project at the end of the quarter.

Students with Documented Disabilities: Students who may need an academic accommodation based on the impact of a disability must initiate the request with Caltech Accessibility Services for Students (CASS). Professional staff will evaluate the request with required documentation, recommend reasonable accommodations, and prepare an Accommodation Letter for faculty dated in the current quarter in which the request is being made. Students should contact Marc Lazar (626-590-8042), the ADA Coordinator for Undergraduate and Graduate Students, as soon as possible, since timely notice is needed to coordinate accommodations. http://cass.caltech.edu/ (Links to an external site.).

Student Wellness Policy: Your health and well-being should be your number one priority. You cannot learn if you are unwell or under extreme duress. As noted earlier, if you are feeling unwell or under extreme duress you should not come to class. This class is designed to be challenging in a positive way, but should not be overwhelming. If you find yourself overwhelmed or encountering other personal challenges during the term, please reach out to me so we can develop a plan for you so that you can be successful in this class in a healthy way. In addition, you are encouraged you to utilize Caltech's student wellness resources. The instructor is always available to talk, and we can always meet virtually or in person (Caltech policy permitting) for a non-academic conversation if necessary. You can also visit the counseling center or talk to a Dean if you find you need help beyond the

Google Drive: We will use a Google Drive folder for the distribution of class materials. If you have trouble accessing the Google Drive please send an email to the instructor to obtain an invitation to access the folder (note that you will need to use your caltech.edu credentials). Students should not distribute the link to the course Google Drive folder, and should not share any course materials.

Office hours: I will have office hours by appointment (rma@caltech.edu).

Communication: We will use Canvas for class announcements. You can also email the instructor, or attend office hours (rma@caltech.edu).

2. Course Outline

Week 1:

September 29: Course Introduction.

Readings: The course syllabus.

October 1: Voting Technology: *Why Can't I Vote On My Phone?*

Note that on 10/1 we will meet on Zoom, the instructor will send the Zoom link on Canvas.

Class guest: Dr. Ben Adida, Voting Works.

Readings:

Why Mobile Voting?

Statement on the Dangers of Internet Voting in Public Elections.

Online Voting is Terrifying and Inevitable.

Week 2:

October 6: Polling and Election Prediction: *Should We Believe The Pundits?*

Readings:

AAPOR, Accuracy of the 2024 General Election Polls (no need to read the appendices unless you are interested).

October 8: Election Administration: *From the trenches.*

Guest: Dr. Thad Hall, Mercer County (PA) Election Director.

Reading: The Human Dimension of Elections

Dr. Hall will join us via Zoom, we will meet in person for this session. The instructor will share a Zoom link, but all devices using that link in the classroom must have their speakers silenced and microphones muted. You will be able to ask questions via Chat, or directly during class.

Week 3:

October 13: Election Fraud & Threats to Democracy: *Does Fraud Exist In the US? How Would We Know? What Can Be Done?*

Reading: Eggers et al., No evidence for systematic voter fraud: A guide to statistical claims about the 2020 election.

October 15: AI & Elections: *Uses and Misuses*

Readings:

Velez et al., Chatbot Voting Advice Applications inform but seldom sway young unaligned voters.

Linegar et al., Towards scalable AI-assisted pre-bunking of election misinformation.

In class reflection.

Research proposals due, October 16 at 5pm Pacific. Powerpoint slide decks, summarizing the research question and information the project will use. No more than 8 slides.

Week 4:

October 20: Registration: *Why Do We Register Voters?*

Reading: *Silvia Kim, Automatic Voter Registration as a Housewarming Gift.*

October 22: Ballot Measures & Ballot Design: *Why Are Ballots So Complicated?*

Reading: *Wand et al., "The Butterfly Did It.".*

Week 5:

October 27: Blue and Red Shifts: *Please Be Patient!*

Reading*: Li et al., "Why Do Election Results Shift After Election Day?".*

Links to an external site.

In class reflection.

October 29: No class, Academic Holiday. Field work opportunities in the afternoon.

Week 6:

November 3: Field Work, No Class. Election Day!

November 5: Field trip to LAC Ballot Tabulation Facility. The bus will pick us up on Michigan near Lot 10 at 9:15am, departing at 9:30am sharp. We will plan to leave the facility at 11:30, so we should return to campus by 12:30pm (perhaps a little earlier, depending on traffic).

Week 7:

November 10: The Election Results: *What Happened Last Week and Why?*

In class reflection.

November 12: Audits, recounts: *Do They Help With Election Integrity?*

Reading*: Lindeman and Stark, A Gentle Introduction to Risk-Limiting Audits*

Research progress reports due, November 12 at 5pm Pacific. Powerpoint slide decks, 8-12 slides, summarizing progress to date and what needs to be done to complete the project by the end of the quarter.

Week 8:

November 17: Money: *Where Does It Come From And Does It Matter?*

Reading: Alvarez et al., "Hidden Donors.".

November 19: Election Reforms: *Should We Change How We Elect Our Representatives?*

Reading: *Sinclair et al., Electoral Innovation and the Alaska System.*

In class reflection.

Week 9:

November 24: Thanksgiving holiday (no class)

November 26: Thanksgiving holiday (no class)

Week 10

December 1: Research lightening presentations.

Final Projects

Final reports due December 6, 2026 5pm Pacific. Powerpoint slide decks, summarizing the research question, methodology, and results. No more than 20 slides.

Final briefings: Each research group will schedule a 15 minute briefing with the instructor, duing the final examination period, December 10, during the 3:30-6:30pm final examination period.